



Understanding unconscious bias

Studies have shown that people can have preferences of which they are unaware that may guide their choices—a state known as unconscious bias. These preferences are often based on stereotypes and beliefs that are ingrained and unconscious. Many organizations offer “unconscious bias training” that aims to bring these hidden prejudices, held by everyone to a greater or lesser extent, to light. Further research indicates that these biases can affect who is recruited even when candidates are presenting with identical CVs, so identifying and addressing these preferences is key to becoming a more open and diverse workplace.

ANTIDISCRIMINATION LAWS

Many countries across the world now have antidiscrimination laws of some kind (see pp.212–215) in order to stop businesses from discriminating against individuals based on protected characteristics. These characteristics can include age, disability, race, religion, gender, or sexual orientation. Every individual must be dealt with fairly, equally, and in accordance with national law, all the way through the employment life cycle—from placing an advertisement for an employee to equal treatment in the workplace. Business practices are falling under greater scrutiny. It is not only a matter of criminal law; in some countries, civil law may also apply, meaning that an employee could claim for personal compensation if an employer is proven to have discriminated against them.



INCLUSION

It is also important to follow through on a pledge to encourage diversity by making sure all members of staff are made to feel welcome. This may mean being flexible to accommodate different ways of doing things. Keeping an open and honest dialogue with all your employees will help everyone feel heard and valued.



“Diversity is being invited to the party; inclusion is being asked to dance.”

Vernā Myers, US activist